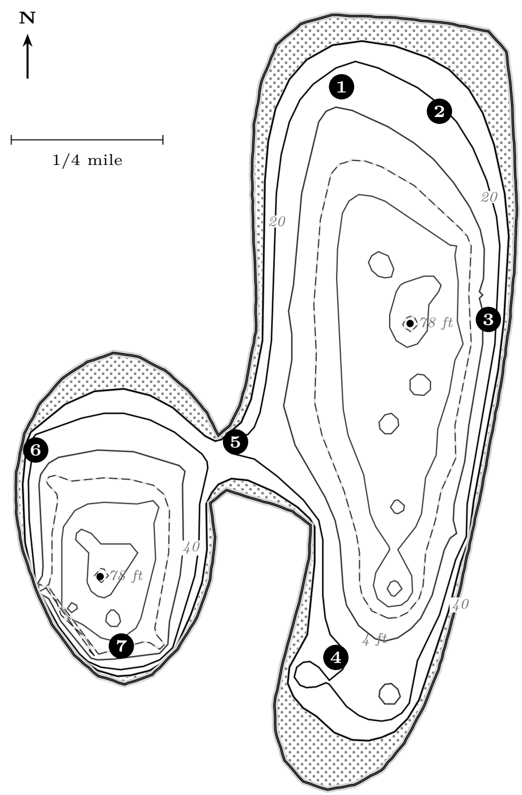
North Lake

Town of Merton

Waukesha County, Wisconsin — 440 acres, 78 ft maximum depth

North Lake sits two miles north of Pine Lake and fishes almost nothing like it. It is a river lake: the Oconomowoc River enters the south-west lobe and leaves at the north-east corner, and that flow keeps the water stained where Pine Lake is glass. Lower clarity is an advantage. Fish here hold shallower, feed later into the morning, and are far less leader-shy. The lake is also two lakes — a long main basin and a round south-west lobe, each with its own deep hole near 78 ft, joined by one narrow neck that every fish in the system has to swim through.

Surface	440 acres (449 acres on the 1898 survey); 3.44 miles of shoreline
Depth	78.4 ft maximum. Two separate holes: one in each basin
Clarity	Low. Stained, river-fed water — shorter weed line, shallower fish, more forgiving of heavier line
Hydrology	Oconomowoc River in at the west end of the lobe, out at the north-east corner. Mud Lake lies immediately south
Fish	Panfish, largemouth bass, smallmouth bass and northern pike (all common), walleye (present)
Access	No municipal ramp. Carry-in public access in the Town of Merton; a DNR fishing pier and small-craft launch have been planned. **Verify what exists and what it costs before you tow anything.** Practically, this is a canoe, kayak or car-top lake



Depth in feet. Schematic — not for navigation. Redrawn from the Wisconsin Conservation Department lake survey sheet (data 1898, revised 21 October 1941; WBIC 850800), published by the Wisconsin DNR as a public document. Contours are reconstructed from that survey's soundings and are generalized; a survey that old will not match a modern sonar log in detail. under 5 ft shoreline 5 & 10 ft 20 ft 30 ft 40 & 60 ft 70 ft ❹ spot

The seven spots, by season

#	Spot	When & what	How
1	North-end flat	**Apr–Jun** panfish, largemouth, pike; **Dec–Feb** panfish under ice.	The broad shallow end of the main basin, under 30 ft nearly all the way across. Weed flats that warm first. Slip bobber at 4–10 ft; spinnerbait over the tops for pike.
2	North-east outlet corner	**Apr–May** and **Sep–Nov** pike and panfish.	Where the lake drains to the river. Moving water concentrates baitfish and the things that eat them. Fish the current seam. Quick-strike rig with a big sucker; jig-and-minnow on the edge.
3	East shoreline drop	**Jun–Sep** smallmouth and walleye; **Oct** pike.	The main basin's east side falls off steadily to the 78 ft hole. Work the 15–30 ft band. Drop-shot, or a lindy rig dragged along the contour.
4	**South-end shoal complex**	**May–Oct**, everything.	Hard humps topping out near 4 ft with deep water all around — the best structure in the lake. Smallmouth and walleye stack on the edges; pike patrol the tops. Start shallow at dawn, work down to 20–25 ft by mid-morning.
5	**The neck**	**All open water.** Pike, bass, walleye, panfish.	The only connection between the two basins: a shallow, current-swept bottleneck. Everything that moves between basins passes through. Anchor off the edge and let bait sit; or cast a jig across and swing it with the current.
6	River inlet, west end of the lobe	**Mar–May** and **Oct–Nov** pike; panfish and bass in summer.	Incoming river water, warmest in spring and coldest in fall. Stained and weedy. Pike stage here before and after the spawn. Big bait, slow.
7	South shore of the lobe	**Jun–Sep** bass and panfish deep; **Jul–Aug** suspended fish.	A short, steep drop into the lobe's own 78 ft hole. Fish the 12–25 ft break; in high summer look for fish suspended off the edge rather than on it.

How North Lake differs from Pine Lake

If you fish both, do not carry one lake's habits to the other.

Fish shallower Stained water means the weed line ends around 8–12 ft instead of 15–20 ft. The whole food chain moves up with it.

Fish later Low-light advantage is smaller here. A cloudy mid-morning on North Lake can beat dawn.

Fish heavier You can get away with heavier line, bigger baits and visible hardware. Save the fluorocarbon and the finesse for Pine.

Two lakes Each basin has its own population behaviour. If the main basin is dead, cross the neck and fish the lobe — it is a different water.

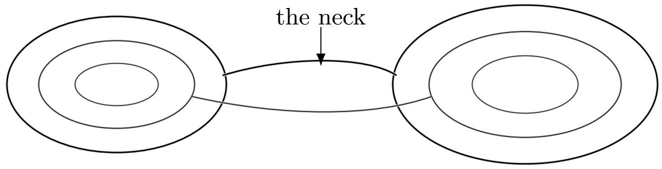
The river matters Spring warm-up, fall cool-down and after heavy rain, the inflow and outflow are the first places to look.

Getting there No trailer ramp. That is why it stays quiet, and it is the best reason to fish it.

Do not switch lakes and methods together

First paired test: North spot _____ against Pine spot _____. Hold ____________________ constant. Record the difference in ____________________; change presentation only after _____ comparable passes.

Treat the two basins as an experiment



North gives you a built-in comparison. Use it:

1. Put one station in the river lobe, one at each side of the neck and one in the main basin. Keep the measurement method identical.
2. On the map, draw the shortest route from spot 7 to spot 3 through spot 5. Mark every contour crossed and the one place current could distort boat track.
3. Compare spots 3 and 7. Which has the tighter break? Write the boat-depth window that keeps a cast in the 12–25 ft band.
4. After rain, predict which station will change clarity and temperature first. What reading would prove the prediction wrong?

Make the comparison falsifiable

I expect the ____________ basin/lobe to be ____________ because ____________. I will compare it with ____________. A single bite does / does not count because ____________.

Old contours, new questions

Question	Verification
Does every fish pass the neck today?	Scan both lips on reciprocal headings; record current, bait and fish instead of assuming traffic.
Does the weed line stop at 8–12 ft?	Cross living vegetation twice in each basin and record the outside edge separately.
Is the mapped access usable and lawful?	Confirm the current public route, signs, craft limits and fees before loading the vehicle.

Measure without changing the method

1. **Name four stations.** Use the river lobe, west lip of the neck, east lip and main-basin break. Record a map number or lawful waypoint.
2. **Depth.** Outside traffic and current, let sonar stabilize. Repeat on the reciprocal heading. Use a marked sounding line only with propulsion stopped, PFD worn and line clear of feet and propeller.
3. **Temperature.** Shade the thermometer. Measure surface, 5, 10 and 20 ft where possible, with the same wait at each depth and station. Do not substitute a surface sonar reading for a lowered thermometer.
4. **Clarity.** Lower a black-and-white Secchi disk on the shaded side to disappearance; raise it to reappearance. Average the two depths and repeat. Stay seated or braced; skip the test when waves make it unsafe.
5. **Context.** Record recent rain, wind, sky, visible current, vegetation height, debris, traffic and confidence in each reading.

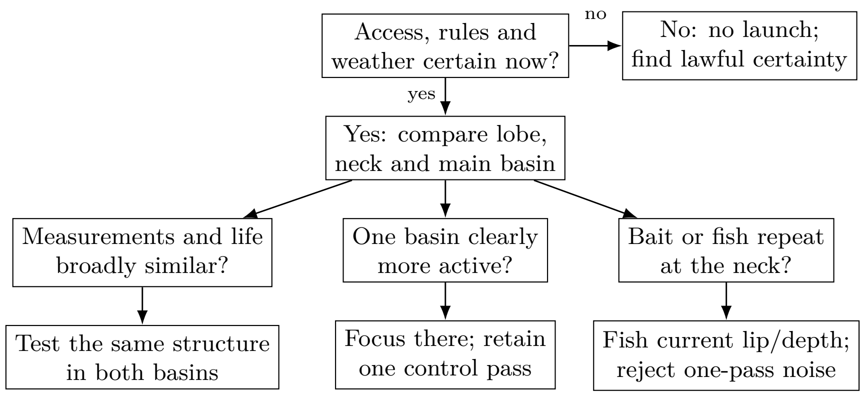
Stained is an observation, not a number

Use the same disk, line, side of craft and units. Temperature and clarity can suggest where to look, but neither proves dissolved oxygen. Measure oxygen with calibrated gear or record it as unknown.

Interrogate the difference

1. Which reading differed most between basins? ____________. Was that difference greater than variation between repeated readings?
2. Did opposite depth headings agree within ______ ft? If not, was slope, weeds, current, speed or setup the likelier cause?
3. Which basin held more repeatable bait marks? ____________. What comparison pass will keep that conclusion honest?

Choose from what repeated



A MAP SYMBOL DOES NOT GRANT ACCESS

Confirm the public route from a current authoritative source and read the signs on site. A path, road label or online pin is not permission. If access, weather, current or a safe return remains uncertain, do not launch.

CHECK THE REGULATIONS BEFORE EVERY TRIP

The 2026–27 rules for this water are the same as Pine Lake's: largemouth and smallmouth bass 14 in minimum, 5 per day, 2 May–7 March, catch-and-release the rest of the year; walleye 18 in minimum, 3 per day; northern pike 26 in minimum, 2 per day; muskellunge 40 in minimum, 1 per day, open water only through 31 December; panfish 25 per day; cisco and whitefish 10 per day. **These change.** The Wisconsin DNR publishes the current rules for this exact water body, and only that publication is authoritative.

Close the comparison at home

A result needs its counterexample

The clearest basin difference was ______________________. It repeated on ________ of ________ passes. The observation most likely to overturn it next trip is ______________________.

1. Compare paired stations, not the best pass from one basin with the worst from the other.
2. Save waypoints with date, current/rain context and confidence. Never publish an unverified access or hazard mark.
3. Write what changed at the neck and what did not.
4. Clean, drain and remove plants and animals before moving equipment.
5. After three comparable trips, revise the "North differs from Pine" claims that the measurements did not support.

Field worksheets

Access and weather gate

Verify today	Evidence, source, time	Go?
Current lawful public access and route		Yes / No
Exact-water regulation; posted ordinance		Yes / No
Forecast, radar, wind direction and gusts		Yes / No
Lightning, fog, waves, current or high water		Yes / No
Craft fit, PFDs, lights, communication, return		Yes / No

Two-basin water log

Date/time	Station	Depth ft	Temp: surface/5/10/20 ft	Secchi: down/up/mean ft	Rain, current, growth, bait, confidence

Claim and counter-evidence log

Time / spot	Claim tested	Evidence for and against	Next move and reason

Next paired comparison

Control	River lobe	Main basin
Station / map spot		
Clock time / duration		
Depth / presentation		
Measurement tools		

Decision written before the trip

I will call the basins meaningfully different only if ______________________________ repeats on ______ paired passes. Otherwise I will record ______________________ as unresolved.